



SNOWBE ONLINE

Patch and Update Management Policy



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Patch and Update
Management Policy

Version1

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Purpose

This policy ensures SnowBe systems remain secure by regularly updating software, operating systems, applications, and firmware to fix known vulnerabilities and reduce cyber risk.

Scope

This policy applies to:

- Office Desktops and laptops
- VPN-connected laptops
- Windows servers
- Wordpress
- Network devices and AWS systems

Definitions

Term	Definition
Patch	A software update that fixes security issues or bugs
Firmware	Software embedded in hardware devices like routers or firewalls
VPN (virtual private network)	A secure connection that allows remote users access to company systems.
Endpoint	A device such as a laptop or desktop
Vulnerability	A weakness that could be exploited by attackers
Critical patch	An update that fixes a high-risk security issue
Compliance	Meeting legal or regulatory requirements

Roles & Responsibilities:

Role	Responsibilities
CISO	Sets patch timelines and approves exceptions
IT Manager	Oversees endpoint patching
Web administrator	Updates wordpress components
Cloud administrator	Manages server and AWS updates.

Policy

- All SnowBe Online resources, as described in the Scope, must be included in a formal patch management program.
- System owners and managers are responsible for identifying, evaluating, and applying appropriate patches to systems under their control.
- Patches must be deployed in accordance with defined patch priority levels (critical, high, medium, low) and timelines established by the IT Manager and approved by the CISO.
- Patches must be applied when a vulnerability is identified and assessed to pose a risk to SnowBe systems, data, or operations. This includes operating system patches, software updates, security fixes, and firmware updates.
- All patching activities must follow established change control procedures, including documentation of patch approvals, deployment, and verification.
- Patching efforts must be coordinated with system backups, testing, and verification to reduce the risk of operational disruption.
- Patch deployment status and compliance must be documented and retained for auditing, compliance (e.g., PCI DSS), and reporting purposes.

Patch Priority and Timeframes

SnowBe Online classifies patching based on severity and business risk:

- Critical Patches – Applied within 72 hours of release or discovery of a severe vulnerability that impacts security or production systems.
- High Priority Patches – Applied within 7 calendar days.
- Medium Priority Patches – Applied within 30 calendar days.
- Low Priority Patches – Applied within 90 calendar days or next scheduled maintenance window.

Emergency exceptions may be granted by the CISO for patches that cannot meet timelines due to operational constraints, provided compensating controls are documented.

Exceptions/Exemptions

Any deviation from this plan must be:

1. Submit deviation form to IT Director

- 2. Approved by the IT Director
- 3. Documented with compensating controls
- 4. Time-limited with a remediation deadline (max of 1 year)

Enforcement

Escalation structure:

- 1. **Verbal Warning** – first minor policy violation
- 2. **Written Warning** – documented repeat violations
- 3. **Suspension of System Access** – short-term, retraining required
- 4. **Job-related Discipline** – reassignment, loss of privileges
- 5. **Termination and Legal Action** – for severe/repeated offenses
- 6. **Criminal Prosecution** – if actions violate state/federal laws

Network or system removal may occur immediately if needed to protect SnowBe systems.

Version History Table

Version #	Implementation Date	Document Owner	Approved By	Description
1.0	20251221	Ethan Platt	SnowBe	Initial Patch and Update Policy

Citations

<https://www.fordham.edu/information-technology/it-security--assurance/it-policies-procedures-and-guidelines/patch-management-policy/>